

- 75 percent of all respondents stated that coupons had at least some influence on their decision to purchase a new product.
- 81 percent of all units purchased with a coupon in the first six months of 2009 were bought by 19 percent of all households. (Nielsen)

That last statistic bears repeating: 19 percent of all households purchased 81 percent of the items that were bought with coupons. In July 2011, *Advertising Age* published an article which reported a dramatic change in the second half of 2010, according to Nielsen panel data: “Coupon enthusiasts” increased from 11 percent of coupon users in 2009 to 13 percent, and that segment of society was responsible for 70 percent of the coupon purchases in 2010. Is this the missing category, or are the true “coupon crazy” an even smaller percentage of households? Nielsen categorizes “coupon enthusiasts” as those using 104 coupons in a six-month period. What if they broke that down even more? What percentage of those couponers used more than 104 coupons *per month*? From the loaded carts and the stacks of coupons used by participants in the *Extreme Couponing* television show, one could conclude that at least those people are buying 90 percent of their purchases with a coupon.

Could these “extreme” couponers be among the “cherry pickers”—that group most feared by the supermarket industry? Extreme cherry pickers shop only discounted sale items and nothing else, reducing the profit margins. That sounds a lot like me, at least in regards to the health and beauty categories of shopping. Until 2010, when prices went up and coupon values on certain products went down, I hadn’t paid more than a dime for toothpaste or a quarter for shampoo in thirty years. Conservatively